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Tensions escalate between US, Iran

Tehran retaliates to strikes, and interim ceasefire collapses

By Jon Gambrell
ASSOCIATED PRESS

DUBAI, United Arab Emirates — The United States intensified its strikes against Iran on Thursday, hitting targets farther north and firing into a ship the U.S. accused of trying to break its naval blockade on the Islamic Republic. Iran retaliated by launching missiles and drones at U.S. allies in the region, and warned its attacks may escalate.

The interim ceasefire agreed to last month has collapsed, and the region has endured days of back-and-forth attacks by the U.S. and Iran as they battle for control of the Strait of Hormuz. Iranian officials say U.S. strikes have killed more than 35 people and wounded over 300 others.

For the first time in this latest round of violence, strikes also reached into areas around Iran's capital, Tehran, showing a widening set of targets for the Americans. The U.S. launched a second wave of strikes late Thursday, saying it was aiming to “further degrade” Iran's military capabilities.

When the U.S. and Israel launched the war on Iran on Feb. 28, Tehran effectively closed the strait to shipping traffic, a move that sent the price of oil soaring and gave Iran major leverage in negotiations.

Col. Ebrahim Zolfaghari, a spokesperson for the Iranian military's Khatam al-Anbiya Central Headquarters, threatened that

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INSIDE

Baseball's second half ready to tee off

The MLB season resumes with the Cubs chasing the Brewers for the division lead and the White Sox tied for first place and exceeding expectations. **Sports**

Scope, scale, beauty in timeless tale

In “The Odyssey,” Christopher Nolan fits his every obsession and jaw-dropping visual he can conjure into every frame of the film. **Arts & Entertainment**



People cross North Michigan Avenue at East Randolph Street on Thursday in Chicago. The city was shrouded in wildfire smoke from Minnesota and Canada. **JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

‘Hazardous’ air

WILDFIRE SMOKE FROM CANADA, MINNESOTA ENVELOPS REGION

COOK COUNTY SHATTERS AIR QUALITY RECORD, EPA DATA SHOWS

By Finnegan Belleau, Lila Hempel-Edgers and Lisa Schencker
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

As wildfire smoke from Canada and Minnesota settled over northern Illinois on Thursday, the presence of a major pollutant quadrupled the previous record set for air quality in Cook County, according to data from the U.S. Environmental Protection Agency.

Concentrations of PM2.5 in the North Shore suburbs by late afternoon reached an index above 900 on a scale that tops out at 500, according to AirNow, a website that combines data from county, state and federal air quality agencies nationwide. In Chicago, levels of PM2.5 registered at 669 on Thursday night.

Cook County's previous record for PM2.5 was 223 on June 27, 2023, according to data from the EPA. Representatives from the EPA could not be reached to

explain the health repercussions of numbers that exceed the scale.

Levels between 200 and 300 are “very unhealthy,” and anything above 300 is “hazardous.” When the forecast is hazardous, everyone should stay indoors and reduce activity levels.

By late Thursday afternoon, Chicago had overtaken Detroit, Minneapolis and Toronto as the most polluted major city in the world, according to Swiss air quality company IQAir.

Ricky Castro, a meteorologist for the National Weather Service, said conditions are expected to improve “sometime during the day” Friday, although a lot is uncertain. Scattered thunderstorms and showers were possible Friday afternoon and could help disperse the smog.

However, Castro also said some areas experiencing less air pollution Thursday afternoon, like the south and west suburbs, could

See **SMOKE** on Page A5



A woman and child ride a bike with masks on North Avenue in Chicago's Humboldt Park neighborhood on Thursday. By late Thursday, Chicago had become the most polluted major city in the world. **ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

IN CHICAGOLAND: Summer comes to a standstill as air quality prompts closures and cancellations across the region. **Page A4**

IN NATION & WORLD: Wildfire smoke darkened skies from the Great Lakes to parts of the East Coast, prompting health warnings. **Page B4**

Johnson's fundraising war chest lags behind

Unusual spot compared with how predecessors maintained their coffers

By Alice Yin and A.D. Quig
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

With two weeks to go before mayoral candidates can start circulating petitions to get on the ballot, Mayor Brandon Johnson's fundraising war chest does not resemble an incumbent ready to defend his seat.

Johnson ended the second quarter with just \$631,309 in his political fund after spending more than he raised, according to state campaign finance reports that were due Wednesday evening.

Johnson spent \$290,437 from the start of April to the end of June



Mayor Brandon Johnson arrives on Wednesday for a City Council meeting at Chicago City Hall. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

but only raised \$108,621, campaign finance records show.

Given that he started last quarter with an already wanting arsenal of \$813,125 in available funds, that places the freshman mayor closer to the lower end of the mayoral pack among expected or declared hopefuls in the 2027 mayor's race.

It's an unusual position compared to how his predecessors

had maintained their coffers at this point before seeking reelection. Lori Lightfoot had \$2.5 million on hand by the middle of 2022, while Rahm Emanuel had \$8.3 million midway through 2014.

But don't count him out yet, Johnson warned reporters on Wednesday.

See **JOHNSON** on Page A2

GOP candidates struggle to raise campaign cash

Bailey raises about \$1.33M while spending more than \$1.28M

By Dan Petrella and Olivia Olander
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Republican nominee for governor Darren Bailey treaded water in the opening stretch of his rematch against Democratic Gov. JB Pritzker in the Nov. 3 general election, raising about \$1.33 million for his campaign fund while spending more than \$1.28 million in the three full months since winning the March 17 GOP primary, state campaign finance records show.

Still, Bailey's fundraising haul was orders of magnitude larger than other Republican statewide candidates in the most recent quarter. That includes U.S. Senate nominee Don Tracy, the former state party chairman who is facing Pritzker's two-time running mate,

Lt. Gov. Juliana Stratton, in the race to replace retiring Democratic Sen. Dick Durbin.

Bailey, a conservative farmer and former lawmaker from southern Illinois, began July with a little less than \$128,000 in his campaign bank account, compared with more than \$3.1 million remaining in the JB for Governor campaign fund, according to quarterly campaign finance disclosures filed Wednesday with the Illinois State Board of Elections.

Lacking the megadonor backing he had in the 2022 race, which he lost by 13 percentage points, Bailey so far has relied heavily on small-dollar contributions. Nearly half of the money he raised in the past three months came from donors giving less than \$150, whose identities don't have to be disclosed.

On June 30, the last day of the most recent reporting period,

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